

GRANDPA LOU, 90, MARRIED 65 YEARS

Don't Text. Call.

*Grandpa Lou's swipe file for the
moments you don't know what to say*



Word-for-word scripts for the 25
moments that keep you up at night

25 CARDS • A USAGE LOG • 5 BONUSES

Find your feeling

Don't read this front to back tonight. Find the line that sounds like your stomach right now, and go to that card.

1 I'm nervous to ask <i>You want to start something and your stomach says no.</i>	1 I want to ask them out, and I'm scared.	8
	2 We've been messaging for weeks, and nothing's happening.	9
	3 They said yes to a call. Now I have to dial.	10
	4 I don't know where to take them, and I'm broke.	11
	5 I can't tell if it's a date or just hanging out.	12
	6 I want to ask out a friend.	13
2 They went quiet <i>The phone is quiet and your head is loud.</i>	7 They haven't texted back in two days.	14
	8 They only text me at 11pm.	15
	9 They're answering slower and slower.	16
	10 They vanished, and now they're back with "hey."	17
3 I want more than this <i>It's something. You want it to be something real.</i>	11 The date went great, and I want another one.	18
	12 I need to ask "what are we?"	19
	13 I like them, and I want to say it first.	20
	14 They're on their phone the whole time we're together.	21
	15 They keep canceling on me.	22
4 I need to say no, or end it <i>You know the answer. You need the words.</i>	16 Someone asked me out, and I'm not interested.	23
	17 A few dates in, and I'm not feeling it.	24
	18 I need to end this situationship.	25
	19 I need to end a real relationship.	26
5 I messed up <i>You said it, sent it or missed it. Now you fix it.</i>	20 I said something dumb.	27
	21 I sent a text I want back.	28
	22 I'm running late, or I have to cancel.	29
6 They crossed a line <i>Something they did isn't okay with you.</i>	23 They said something that hurt me.	30
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A letter from Lou

Dear kid,

Lemme guess. It's late, the phone's in your hand, and you've typed the same message eleven times and deleted it eleven times.

Here's something nobody tells you: everybody thinks they're the only one who doesn't know what to say. I drove a city bus in Brooklyn for thirty-eight years. I watched ten thousand first dates and a few hundred breakups in that big mirror over my head, and lemme tell you something. Nobody knew what to say. Not the good-looking ones, not the ones in the nice shoes. Nobody.

Me neither. In 1955 there was a girl at the bakery on the corner. Angie. I bought a loaf of bread from her every morning for three weeks before I said one word. Then I asked her properly: Saturday, two o'clock. I had a dime and a penny in my pocket. A soda was a dime, so it was one soda, two straws, and I left the penny for a tip like a big shot.

Sixty-five years I was married to my Angie, and not once, not once, did I text her. I lost her in 2021. I wear my ring on a chain now, because my knuckles got too big for it. The ring didn't get smaller. I got bigger.

So here's what this is. It's the words: the exact words for the moments that keep you up at night. When you're scared to ask. When they go quiet. When you want more, or you need out, or you messed up. Every card has what to say on the phone, the text to send if you really have to, what not to say, and what to do if the answer is no.

There are no tricks in here. I don't do tricks, and no script makes anybody want you. Nothing does, and you don't want somebody who had to be talked into it. What a script does is get the words out of your chest and into the air, so you get a real answer. A real answer you can live with, even a no. It's the guessing that keeps you up.

So find your page. Take a breath. Pick up the phone.

Don't text. Call.

Lou

Why this works

Most of the pain in dating isn't the no. It's the guessing.

Lemme tell you what you paid for, because you should know.

It turns a guess into a question.

Every card does the same small thing. It takes the story you tell yourself at midnight, “they’re bored of me,” “I ruined it,” and swaps it for a question you can actually ask. A question gets an answer. An answer, even a no, lets you sleep.

It puts your voice back in.

When you text, the other person has to guess your tone, and people guess wrong all the time. Researchers who study this have turned up two things worth knowing: people tend to think their tone comes across in writing better than it really does, and they tend to expect a phone call to be more awkward than it turns out to be. A voice carries the warm part, the kidding part and the nervous part all at once. A text carries the words and leaves the rest to their imagination, at eleven at night, which is the worst time for anybody’s imagination.

It’s brave, and people can feel it.

Anybody can type. A call says, “I meant this enough to risk my voice.” That one’s not science. That’s ninety years of watching people.

It gets you past the first sentence.

When you’re nervous, your head goes blank. A script gets the first sentence out of your mouth. After the first sentence, you’re just talking, and you’re better at that than you think.

WHAT THIS ISN'T

It isn't a way to make anybody want you. **No script makes anyone want you**, and I'd be careful with anybody who says theirs does. It isn't therapy, and it won't fix a broken heart by Friday. And if what's happening to you is scary, it's not a dating problem at all. Go to card 25 (p. 32).

How to use this file

It's not a book. It's a drawer full of index cards. You open it when you need it.

- ① **Find your feeling.** The index on page 2 sorts every card by how you feel, not by what happened. Your stomach knows which one it is.
- ② **Take the card.** Read the rule first. It's one line. If you remember nothing else, remember that.
- ③ **Make it yours.** The words are a starting point, not a costume. Change anything that doesn't sound like you, and fill in the [brackets]. Then say it out loud once, to the mirror, the dog or the fridge. The fridge never laughed at me.
- ④ **Call.** If you can't call yet, use the text, but the text has one job only: to set up the call, or a plan with a day and a time. Face to face counts double.
- ⑤ **Write one line in the log** on page 33. Date, card, what happened, how you felt. That's the only homework in here.

WHAT IT'LL FEEL LIKE

Before

Your stomach will do the thing. That's normal, and it doesn't mean stop.

The first few seconds

Your voice might wobble. Mine did, and I was only asking about a soda.

After

Lighter. Almost every time, whatever they said.

Start your log right now

The conversation I've been putting off: _____

Today's date: _____

When you've had it, tick the box on page 34.

No crisis tonight? Good. Read the five cards on page 35.

A no is an answer

THE GIFT RULE

A no is an answer. An answer is a gift.

In my bus mirror I saw plenty of people get a no. Lemme tell you who did fine: the ones who got an answer. The ones who suffered were the ones still standing at the stop, waiting on a bus that was never coming.

So when it goes wrong, and sometimes it will, here's what you do.

- **Say thank you, and mean it.** "Thanks for telling me" is the classiest sentence in the English language.
- **Don't argue, and don't ask twice.** A no isn't the start of a negotiation. You don't need their reasons, either.
- **Do something with your hands.** Walk around the block. Make a sandwich. Call somebody who loves you.
- **Write it in the log.** Later you'll want to see how brave you were.

And when you fumble it? You said "um" nine times, you forgot to say the day, you texted when you meant to call. No do-overs. You don't redo a call, you don't apologize for being nervous, and you don't make up for it with three extra texts. You just make the next call, whenever the next one comes.

HOW TO READ THE ANSWER

"Not Tuesday, I'm busy."	Not a no. Ask for one other day, once.
"Maybe," twice.	A no, being polite. Let it go.
One call, one message, nothing back.	An answer, for now. The phone goes in the drawer.
"I'm not looking for anything right now."	A no. Believe it the first time.
"Yes."	A yes. Don't argue with that one either.

The log in the back is a record, not a report card.

Make it fit your life

Every card says call. Here's what that means when your life doesn't look like the card.

If you're shy

Shy isn't a flaw, kid. Shy people make the best callers, because they listen. Use the text on each card first, to book the call: "Can I call you at seven?" Then nobody's surprised, including you. Write your first sentence on a piece of paper and read it. Nobody can see the paper.

If you live with anxiety

Make the call smaller. Pick the time ahead and put it in your calendar. Read straight off the card; that's what it's for. Shaky hands are allowed, and the other person can't see them. One card at a time, not five. If anxiety is running your whole life and not just your love life, talk to a doctor or a counselor. Going is the strong move.

If it's long-distance

Then the phone isn't the extra, it's the house. Pick a standing time and keep it like a bus schedule. Mind the time zones, and say goodnight on the call, not in a text. And keep the next visit on the calendar with a real date on it. Long distance with no next date is a pen pal.

If you're deaf or hard of hearing

I wear a hearing aid in my right ear, so half the time on the phone I'm saying "What?" My grandson turned the captions on for me, and now I read faster than I hear. So when I say call, I mean talk where they can hear you or see you, in real time, as yourself. A video call with captions counts. Signing counts. Voice notes count, if they work for you. And if text is how you talk, text is fine. The rule was never about the phone. It's about not hiding behind it.

WHEN IT'S MORE THAN NERVES

If you're scared of someone, go to [card 25 \(p. 32\)](#) now. If you're in a dark place, not just a sad week, call or text **988** in the US, or call Samaritans on **116 123** in the UK and Ireland. That's not failing. That's the strongest call you can make.

I want to ask them out, and I'm scared.

THE DAY-AND-A-TIME RULE

Sometime is never.

Nicky says to ask somebody out these days you need “rizz.” Riz? Like rice? Kid, you don’t need rice. Scared is fine. Scared means it matters. But scared people ask foggy questions, and foggy questions get foggy answers. So you ask it plain, the way it’s written below. A day and a time.

SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hi, it’s [your name]. Have you got a minute? *Wait for the answer.*

Okay, I’ll just say it. I like talking to you. Would you like to get a coffee with me on Tuesday, around six? *If they hesitate:* And if Tuesday’s no good, pick a day that works for you.

IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Free for a quick call tonight around eight? I want to ask you something, and it’s a good something.

DON’T SAY

~~“We should hang out sometime.”~~ That’s a wish, not an invitation.

IF THEY SAY NO / DON’T ANSWER

If they say no: “No problem, thanks for being straight with me.” And mean it. Then hang up a hero, because you asked, and most people never do.

If they say “I can’t Tuesday,” that’s not a no. Ask what day works. If they say “maybe” twice, that’s a no wearing a hat. If they don’t pick up, leave one short message with the day and the time in it, and let them call you back. You’re asking, not chasing.

We've been messaging for weeks, and nothing's happening.

THE BAKERY RULE

You can only buy so much bread before you have to say something.

In 1955 I bought a loaf every morning for three weeks from a girl I was too scared to talk to. I ate so much bread my mother thought I was sick. Weeks of messages back and forth? Same bread, kid. It's nice, it's safe, and it's going nowhere. The next step is a voice, and then a face.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hi, it's [your name], from all the messages. Is this an okay time? *Let them answer.*

I figured after [three weeks] of typing, I'd like to actually talk to you. I've really liked getting to know you, and I'd love to meet in person. Are you free [Thursday] after work for a coffee? Somewhere easy, like [place].

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

I've really liked talking to you. Could I call you tomorrow around seven? I'd love to know what you sound like.

🚫 DON'T SAY

"haha-same" Message four hundred of the same bread. Ask for the date.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they'd rather not talk on the phone yet, that's fine. Skip straight to the plan: "No problem. Want to just meet for a coffee on [Thursday]?" Some people are better face to face.

If they dodge the call and the coffee, they like the messages more than the meeting. That's allowed, and it's an answer. Wish them well, stop buying bread, and give those evenings to somebody who wants to meet you. And when you do meet somebody, pick somewhere public and tell a friend where you'll be. Old-fashioned, and smart.

They said yes to a call. Now I have to dial.

THE REASON RULE

You don't need a speech, you need a reason.

When I was courting, the phone hung on the kitchen wall with a cord this long. You couldn't pace, you couldn't hide, you just talked. And I never once had a speech ready. I had a reason: Saturday, or a picture I wanted to see. A reason gets you through the first thirty seconds. After that, it's two people talking.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hi, it's [your name]. Is now a good time? I was thinking about Saturday and I wanted to hear your voice.

So how did [the thing they told you about] go? *Listen. Ask one more question about it.*

I should let you go, but I'd love to see you Saturday. How about two o'clock at [place]?

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Still good to talk at seven? I'll call you then.

🚫 DON'T SAY

"So... um... what's up?" That's not a reason. That's a shrug.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If it's a bad time: "No problem, when's better?" Then call at exactly that time. Not around then. Then.

If they don't pick up at the time you agreed, leave one short message: "Hi, it's [your name], calling like I said. Call me back when you can." Then let them call you. If they move the call twice, ask once, kindly: "Do you still want to do this? Either answer is okay." There's a fill-in version of this call on [page 37](#).

I don't know where to take them, and I'm broke.

THE TUESDAY RULE

First date on a Tuesday. A coffee and a walk, one hour.

My first date with Angie was a Saturday at two, on eleven cents. Today I say Tuesday. Nobody's trying to impress anybody on a Tuesday, and one hour means nobody's trapped. If it's good, the hour turns into two all by itself. And lemme tell you, nobody remembers what a first date cost. They remember whether you listened.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hi, it's [your name]. I'd love to see you, and I'd like to keep it simple. How about Tuesday after work? We get a coffee and take a walk around [the park], about an hour.

If we're having a good time, we keep walking. My treat, since I asked.

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Coffee and a walk on Tuesday? Around six at [place], about an hour, my treat.

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~"Sorry, I can't really afford anything nice."~~ Don't apologize for your wallet. Pick something good.

🙋 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they say no to the date, it wasn't the price. Thank them and let it go. If Tuesday doesn't work, offer one other day, then let them pick.

If they'd rather do something fancy, be honest: "I'm keeping things simple right now, but I'd really like to see you." Anybody worth knowing will take a walk. And when you run out of ideas, there are ten cheap Tuesday dates on page 39.

I can't tell if it's a date or just hanging out.

THE SAY-THE-WORD RULE

If it's a date, call it a date.

In my day, nobody had to wonder. You said the word “date,” you put on your one good shirt, and everybody knew where they stood. Now it's all “hanging out,” and half of you are sitting across a table not knowing if it counts. One word fixes it, and you can be the one who says it first.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hey, before [Friday], can I ask you something so I'm not guessing? *Wait.*

I'd like it to be a date. A real one. Is that how you see it too? Either answer is okay. I'd just like us to be on the same page.

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Looking forward to [Friday]. Can I call you tonight for two minutes? Quick question about it, nothing bad.

🚫 DON'T SAY

“So is this, like, a date or whatever, haha?” Don't ask with a laugh to hide behind. Ask it straight.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they say yes, a date: wonderful. Now you both know, and you can stop reading tea leaves.

If they say they see you as a friend: “Thanks for telling me. I'm glad I asked.” Then be honest with yourself about whether you can enjoy [Friday] as friends. If you can't, it's okay to bow out kindly. If they say “I don't know yet,” that's fair too. Go, have a nice time, and let it be what it is.

I want to ask out a friend.

THE EASY-NO RULE

Ask once, out loud, and make it easy to say no.

Half the good marriages I know started as friends. The other half started at a bakery. Here's the thing: a friendship that can't survive one honest question wasn't as strong as you thought. So you ask once, you make the no easy, and you mean it when you say you'll be fine.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Can I tell you something kind of big? *Wait.* I like you, as more than a friend. I'd love to take you on a real date, [Friday] at [seven].

And if you don't feel the same, that's completely okay. I mean it. I'd rather ask than wonder, and I'm not going anywhere either way.

💬 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Are you around for a call later? I want to ask you something, and I'd feel silly typing it.

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~"This is probably stupid, just forget I said anything."~~ If you ask, stand behind it.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they say no: "Okay. Thank you for being honest. We're good." Then prove it. Be normal the next time you see them. If you need a little distance for a while, take it quietly, without making them feel guilty.

If they need time to think, give them a few days and don't bring it up. If they say yes, congratulations: you already know they like your company. A friend who says no is still a friend. That's what the easy no is for.

They haven't texted back in two days.

THE ONE KNOCK RULE

Call once. If there's no answer, send one message. Then the phone goes in a drawer.

Listen. Two days of quiet is not a funeral. People lose their phones, work a double, get the flu, get shy. And you can't turn a red light green by staring at it. Thirty-eight years I drove a bus, I tried. So you knock once, nice and friendly, and you go live your life. An answer or no answer, both are answers.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hi, it's [your name]. Is now an okay time? *Wait for the answer.*

I hadn't heard from you in a couple of days, and I'd rather call than guess. I've really enjoyed getting to know you, and I'd love to see you Thursday. If you're not feeling it, that's okay too. I'd just rather know.

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Hey, I've enjoyed getting to know you. If you're still interested, I'd love to see you Thursday. If not, no hard feelings.

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~"Hello????????????????"~~ Fifteen question marks never got anybody an answer faster.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they say no, or "I'm not feeling it": "Thanks for telling me. I mean it." Then you can stop guessing, and that's a gift ([page 6](#)).

If nothing comes back, that's your answer for now. No second call tomorrow, no "just checking in." The phone goes in a drawer, and you go have dinner with somebody who's glad to see you. If they turn up next week with a real reason and a real plan, wonderful. If they turn up with "hey," that's [card 10 \(p. 17\)](#).

They only text me at 11pm.

THE ELEVEN O'CLOCK RULE

If somebody only texts you after eleven, you're not a plan.

I was in bed by ten most of my life. Bus drivers start early. So I'm no expert on eleven o'clock, but I know this much: if somebody only remembers you when the lights are off, you're the late show, not the plan. If that's what you both want, that's your business. If you want more, ask for a Saturday afternoon.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hey, it's [your name]. Can I be straight with you about something? *Let them answer.*

I like you, and I've noticed we only really talk late at night. I'd like more than that. I'd like to see you in the daytime, on an actual date. Are you free [Saturday] around [noon]?

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

I'm not up for late-night texting anymore, but I'd love to see you in the daytime. Free [Saturday] around [noon]?

🚫 DON'T SAY

“hey” Sent back at 11:04. Hey is not a question, and you don't owe it an answer.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they say yes to Saturday, good. Now you get to find out who they are in the daylight.

If they dodge the daytime and keep texting at eleven, that's your answer, and it's a clear one. You don't have to argue about it. Put the phone on silent at ten and go to sleep. That's not a game. It's a bedtime.

They're answering slower and slower.

THE DIMMER SWITCH RULE

When somebody turns the lights down slow, you're allowed to ask if the party's over.

In my bus mirror I watched a lot of couples go quiet a little more each week. Same two people, a little farther apart on the seat. Usually one of them already knew, and the other one was waiting to be told. You don't have to wait to be told. You can ask.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hey, I'm glad you picked up. I want to ask you something, and any answer is okay. *Breathe.*

It feels like things have slowed down between us. Are you still interested in this? If you're not, I'd honestly rather know. I won't make it weird.

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Free for a quick call tonight? Five minutes. I want to ask you something simple, and any answer is fine.

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~"No worries if you're busy!! :)"~~ The fourth time you send it, you're turning the dimmer down too.

🔗 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they say they're not interested: "Okay. I appreciate you telling me." That stings, and it's still a gift ([page 6](#)).

If they say "I'm just busy," ask for a day and a time. Busy people who want to see you find one. If they don't answer at all, the dimmer just clicked off. Let it be off, and don't rattle the switch.

They vanished, and now they're back with "hey."

THE FRONT DOOR RULE

If you left by the back door, you come back by the front, with an explanation.

Ghosting. Like the movie? No, Nicky says, it's when somebody disappears without a word. Then one day they're back with one word, like nothing happened. You don't owe them a party. You don't owe them a fight, either. But before you open the door, you get to ask what happened.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hey. I got your message. *Keep it calm. Nobody's on trial.*

Honestly, you disappeared for [three weeks], and I'm not going to pretend that didn't happen. If you want to see me, I'd need to hear what happened, and I'd want a real plan. If not, I understand.

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Good to hear from you. If you want to catch up properly, call me this week.

🚫 DON'T SAY

"omg hiii!!" Like nothing happened? Something happened. You were there.

🔒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they call with a real explanation and a real plan, you decide whether you believe it. You're allowed to give a second chance. You're not required to.

If all you get back is another "hey," that's the back door again. Leave it shut, and don't send a speech about why. You already showed them the front door. They know where it is.

The date went great, and I want another one.

THE MONDAY SAUCE RULE

Sauce is better the next day. So is “I had a really good time.”

Angie’s sauce was good on Sunday and better on Monday. The recipe’s in Rosemarie’s head now, and she won’t tell Joey. Anyway. You had a nice time? Don’t play it cool for three days. Playing it cool is how good things go cold. Call the next day and say so.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hey, it’s me. I just wanted to say I had a really good time last night. Really.

I’d love to see you again. Are you free [Friday] at [seven]? I was thinking we could try [that place you said you’d never been to].

💬 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Had a really good time last night. Free [Friday] at [seven]? I’d love to see you again.

🚫 DON’T SAY

~~“lol that was fun”~~ Three days later, to look relaxed. That’s not cool. That’s cold.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON’T ANSWER

If they say they didn’t feel it, thank them: “I’m glad you told me. I had fun.” Mean it, and let it be one good night. That’s not nothing.

If they’re happy to hear from you but busy, ask what day works and let them pick. If they don’t answer, you said a nice, true thing to another person, and that’s never wasted. Give it a few days, then let it go.

I need to ask “what are we?”

THE SITUATION-SHIP RULE

A boat with no captain just goes in circles.

A situation-ship. Nicky had to say it three times. I tapped my hearing aid, I thought it was broken. A ship? With no captain and no map? Listen. If you’ve been on that boat for months and you want to know where it’s going, you’re allowed to ask the other passenger.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Can I ask you something real? *Pause.* I like what we have, and I’ve been wondering where it’s going.

For me, I’d like **[us to be exclusive / us to be together, for real]**. What do you want? Whatever it is, I can handle it. I just want to know.

💬 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Can we talk on the phone tonight? I want to ask you something about us, and it’s nothing scary.

🚫 DON’T SAY

~~“I’m chill with whatever.”~~ If you’re not. Pretending to be chill is how you spend a year on that boat.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON’T ANSWER

If they want the same thing, wonderful. Now it has a name. If they say “I don’t want labels,” that’s an answer too, and you get to decide whether it’s enough for you. If it isn’t, you can get off the boat. The words for that are on card 18 (p. 25).

If they say “I don’t know,” give it a little time, then ask once more. If “I don’t know” turns into a whole season, it’s a no.

I like them, and I want to say it first.

THE SOMEBODY-HAS-TO RULE

Somebody has to say it first. Might as well be the brave one.

Every week somebody in the comments asks, “What if they don’t feel the same?” Then you’ll know, and you’ll be okay. But what if they do, and you both just sat there? Like two kids on the phone at night: “You hang up first.” “No, you hang up first.” Somebody’s gotta go first, sweetheart.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Can I tell you something? *Let them say yes.* I really like you. Not in a casual way. I like how you [remember every little thing I tell you].

You don’t have to say anything back right now. I just didn’t want to keep it to myself anymore. *Then stop, and let it land.*

💬 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Free for a call at nine? I’ve got something nice to tell you, and I want to say it out loud.

🚫 DON’T SAY

“I think I like you, but whatever, it’s dumb.” Don’t take it back in the same breath.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON’T ANSWER

If they feel the same, enjoy that, kid. That’s the best phone call there is.

If they say they’re not there yet, that’s not a no. Don’t push, don’t ask again next week, and let it breathe. If they say they don’t feel that way: “Thank you for telling me. I’m still glad I said it.” Then give yourself some room. You were brave. Brave is never the mistake.

They're on their phone the whole time we're together.

THE FACE-DOWN RULE

On a date, the phone goes face down.

Sunday lunch at my house, eight grandkids, and you'd think half of them were expecting a call from the President. So at my table, phones go in the bread basket. On a date, face down is enough. Listen, wanting somebody's attention isn't needy. It's the whole point of sitting across from them.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Can I bring something up? It's small, but it matters to me. *Pause.*

When we're out, it feels like your phone gets more of you than I do. I don't think you mean anything by it. I just miss you when you're sitting right there. Could we keep our phones face down when we're together?

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Can I call you later? There's a small thing I want to bring up. Nothing dramatic.

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~"Am I boring you or something?"~~ That's a fight starter, not a question.

🙄 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they say "you're right, sorry" and they actually try, that's a good person with a bad habit. Everybody's got one. Put yours face down too, so it's fair.

If they roll their eyes and keep scrolling, it's not a habit anymore. It's a choice, and it tells you where you rank. You're allowed to want to rank above a phone.

They keep canceling on me.

THE SCHEDULE RULE

Once is bad luck. Every week is a schedule.

When I was courting Angie, I called her every night at seven. Not seven-ish. Seven. One cancel is just life. But when it's every time, they're telling you something they won't say out loud. If they wanted to, they'd call. You can ask them to say the rest.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hey, have you got a few minutes? I want to be honest about something. *Wait.*

The last [three] times we made plans, they fell through, and I'm starting to feel like I'm not a priority. If things are hard for you right now, I get it, and I'd rather you just tell me. Do you want to keep doing this?

💬 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Can I call you tomorrow at [seven]? I'd like to talk about our plans, and not over text.

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~"No worries!!"~~ The fourth time, when you're worried. If it's a worry, say it's a worry.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they own it and make a plan they actually keep, good. That's a real sign, and people do get better.

If they cancel the next one too, you don't need another talk. Stop making plans, and tell them once, kindly: "I think we want different things. Take care." Don't keep a seat warm for somebody who never shows up.

Someone asked me out, and I'm not interested.

THE THANK-YOU-FIRST RULE

Somebody was brave enough to ask. Thank them before you say no.

I know what that ask cost them. When I asked Angie, I had eleven cents and a knot in my stomach the size of a meatball. So thank them, then tell them straight. A quick, kind no is a gift. A “maybe, let me see” is a week of somebody staring at their phone. And if they asked by text, a text back is fine. Answer the way you were asked.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hey, thank you for asking me. Really, that took guts.

I want to be honest with you: I don't feel that way. But I'm glad you asked, and I liked how you did it.

📱 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Thank you for asking, that was really kind. I want to be honest: I don't feel that way, and I didn't want to leave you guessing.

🚫 DON'T SAY

“I'm just really busy right now.” When the truth is no. Busy gets asked again next month.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they're gracious about it, great. That's a good person, and somebody else is going to be lucky.

If they push (“Why not? Just one coffee?”), you don't owe them a reason or a second answer: “I already answered. Take care.” If they won't let it go, or they make you uneasy, that's [card 24](#) (p. 31). And if you're ever scared, go to [card 25](#) (p. 32).

A few dates in, and I'm not feeling it.

THE PULL-THE-CORD RULE

You don't owe anybody a speech. You owe them one sentence.

On my bus, when you wanted off, you pulled the cord. The bell rang, I pulled over, you got off. Nobody jumped out the window. Disappearing on somebody after a few dates is jumping out the window. Pull the cord instead, the same week you know. After a date or two, a kind text counts as pulling the cord.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hi, [their name]. Have you got a minute? *Let them answer.*

I've really enjoyed meeting you, and I didn't want to just disappear on you. I'm not feeling it, I wish you well. *That's it. You can stop there.*

💬 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

I've enjoyed our dates, and I want to be straight with you instead of disappearing. I'm not feeling it, I wish you well.

🚫 DON'T SAY

"Let's just see where it goes." When you already know where it goes. Say so.

🛑 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they ask why, keep it simple: "It's just a feeling. It's nothing you did." You don't owe them a list.

If they argue, don't debate. You're not negotiating: "I've made up my mind, but I'm glad we met."

If they don't answer at all, that's fine. You did the decent thing, and you're done.

I need to end this situationship.

THE SHORT-IS-KIND RULE

Short is kind. The long version is for you, not for them.

Time to get off the boat from [card 12 \(p. 19\)](#). Do it on the phone, or better, in person. Not with a meme. You say the true thing in one breath, you wish them well, and then you stop talking. That's the hard part. Most people keep going because the quiet scares them. Let it be quiet.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hey. Have you got a few minutes? I want to be honest with you.

I've realized I want something more serious, and I don't think it's going to be us. I wish you well. *Then stop.*

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Can I call you tonight? I want to talk about us, and it's not a text kind of thing.

🚫 DON'T SAY

"I'm so sorry, I'm sorry, okay, so basically, the thing is..." Don't explain for twenty minutes or apologize six times.

🔒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they ask, "Can we still hang out?" that's your call. If hanging out is how you got on this boat, "No thanks" is a whole answer. If they promise to change now that you're leaving, you can listen, and still go.

If they don't pick up, send the short version as a message, so it isn't left hanging. And if you don't feel safe with this person, a message is fine, and so is blocking. Then read [card 25 \(p. 32\)](#).

I need to end a real relationship.

THE NO-TRIAL RULE

A breakup is a decision, not a trial. You don't need to win the case.

After a long time together, you tell them face to face if it's safe, on the phone if face to face isn't possible, and never by text. And leave the list of everything they did wrong at home. You're not a lawyer, and they're not on trial. You decided. That's enough. If you're scared of how they'll take it, skip this card and go to [card 25 \(p. 32\)](#).

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

I need to tell you something hard, and I've thought about it for a long time. *Breathe.*

I'm ending our relationship. This isn't a fight, and it isn't something we can fix. I've decided. I care about you, and I'm sorry this hurts.

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Can we talk tonight at [seven], in person? It's important, and it can't be a text.

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~"Maybe we can try again someday."~~ If you don't mean it. False hope is the cruelest thing you can leave behind.

🔒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they beg, bargain or get angry, you don't have to argue: "I hear you. I'm not changing my mind." Say it as many times as you need, but don't reopen the case. Keys, stuff and the lease can wait for another conversation.

Have a friend you can call right after, or somewhere to go for the night. And if at any point you feel unsafe, leave, and go to [card 25 \(p. 32\)](#).

I said something dumb.

THE I-WAS-WRONG RULE

“I was wrong. I’m sorry.” Then stop talking.

Sixty-five years of marriage, I said plenty of dumb things. The fix was never a big speech. It was “I was wrong, I’m sorry,” and then closing my mouth, which for me was always the hard part. A long sorry turns into a speech about you. A short one is about them.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hey, it’s me. I said something dumb the other night about [the thing].

It was thoughtless, and I’m sorry. You didn’t deserve that. That’s all. I just didn’t want it sitting there between us.

📱 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

I said something dumb, and I want to apologize properly, not by text. Can I call you tonight?

🚫 DON’T SAY

~~“I’m sorry if you were offended.”~~ That’s not a sorry. That’s a bill.

🕒 IF THEY SAY NO / DON’T ANSWER

If they’re not ready to hear it, leave it there. A sorry isn’t a ticket you get to cash in, so don’t keep apologizing until they forgive you. If they need time, give it.

If they’re done, they’re done, and you take the lesson to the next person: think one second longer before you talk. I’m still working on that one at ninety.

I sent a text I want back.

THE NOON RULE

What you sent at midnight, you fix by noon.

My grandkids tell me people send things at two in the morning they'd never say at two in the afternoon. In my day the phone was on the kitchen wall, and my mother was in the kitchen. That kept things short. So: sleep, coffee, then one plain apology before lunch.

SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hi. So, about the message I sent last night. That was too much, it was late, and I'm sorry.

You don't need to answer it. I just wanted to say so out loud, instead of pretending it didn't happen.

IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Last night's message was too much. I'm sorry. Can I call you at lunch and say it properly?

DON'T SAY

~~"lol ignore that, I was so drunk"~~ The drink didn't hold the phone. You did.

IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

Then you let it rest. One apology, by noon, then hands off. No follow-up, no "Did you see my message?" If they write back kindly, lucky you.

If they don't, take the lesson and charge your phone in the kitchen overnight for a while. Mine lived in the kitchen my whole life, and I never once sent anything I regretted at two in the morning.

I'm running late, or I have to cancel.

THE BUS DRIVER'S RULE

Late is late. Don't explain the traffic. Apologize for the wait.

Thirty-eight years I drove a city bus, and I can tell you, nobody waiting at a stop in the rain cares why you're late. They care that somebody told them. So you call before the time, not after, and you give them the new time like you mean it.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Hi, it's [your name]. I'm so sorry, I'm running about [twenty] minutes late. That's on me. I'll be there at [7:20]. If that wrecks your night, we can move it.

If you have to cancel: I have to cancel tonight, and I'm sorry. I know you planned around it. Can I take you out [Thursday] at [seven] instead? My treat.

💬 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Running [20] minutes late, my fault, so sorry. I'll be there by [7:20]. Still okay, or should we move it to [Thursday]?

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~"Traffic was crazy."~~ Ten minutes after you were due. That's a weather report, not an apology.

🙄 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they're upset, let them be upset. You earned it. Say "I understand, and I'm sorry," and don't argue your case.

If they'd rather call the night off, accept it without a fuss and offer one new day. And next time, leave when you think you're early. That's what on time looks like.

They said something that hurt me.

THE OUCH RULE

If it stung, say “ouch” out loud. What they do next is your answer.

Everybody says a dumb thing sometimes. I’ve said a few hundred. So the first time, you figure it was dumb, not mean, and you tell them. Not in a text with three paragraphs. Out loud, once, plain. It’s never the dumb thing that does the damage. It’s the dumb thing nobody mentions, sitting there for a year.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

Can I mention something from the other night? *Wait for the okay.* When you said [what they said], it stung.

I don’t think you meant it that way, but I wanted you to know. I don’t want to sit on it and let it get bigger.

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

Can I call you at [eight]? Something from the other night is still on my mind, and I want to clear it up.

🚫 DON’T SAY

“It’s fine.” When it isn’t. “It’s fine” is how small things get big.

🔍 IF THEY SAY NO / DON’T ANSWER

A good person says “I’m sorry, I didn’t think.” A not-so-good one tells you you’re too sensitive. Now you know which one you’ve got.

If it keeps happening after you said it plain, it’s not a slip anymore. It’s a habit, and you can leave: the words are on card 18 (p. 25) and card 19 (p. 26). If what they say makes you feel scared or small all the time, go to card 25 (p. 32).

They keep pushing after I said no.

THE ONE-WORD RULE

No is one word. It doesn't need an explanation, and it doesn't get a recount.

Pushing comes in a lot of flavors: “come on,” “just one more drink,” “you said maybe last time,” “if you really liked me.” Doesn't matter the flavor. You said no, to coming over, to moving faster, to whatever it was, and that's the whole conversation. Anybody worth your time hears it the first time.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

I want to say something clearly, so there's no confusion. *Slow down. Say it like a fact, because it is one.*

I said no to [staying over / moving faster / that], and I meant it. I'm not going to keep explaining. If we're going to keep seeing each other, I need you to stop asking.

💬 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

I said no, and I meant it. Please don't ask again.

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~“Maybe another time.”~~ If you mean no. A soft no just gets asked again.

🔁 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If they argue, sulk or ask again, that's your answer about them. You don't owe a second no, but if you want one: “I already answered.” Then end the call.

If they don't stop, if you feel scared, or if they push with their hands instead of their words, go to card 25 (p. 32) right now. That isn't dating anymore.

If they scare you, this isn't a dating problem.

THE BRAVEST CALL RULE

The bravest call in this whole file isn't to them.

Listen to me, sweetheart. If you're scared of how they'll react, if they check your phone, decide who you can see, control your money, threaten you or hurt you, no card in here is for that. That's when you call somebody whose whole job is to help. It isn't weak. It's the strongest call you'll ever make.

📞 SAY THIS (ON THE PHONE)

To a helpline. It's free and confidential, and somebody answers day and night.

Hi. I'm not sure if this counts, but I'm scared of the person I'm with. **[One thing that happened.]** I don't know what to do next.

US: National Domestic Violence Hotline, 1-800-799-7233

UK: Refuge, National Domestic Abuse Helpline, 0808 2000 247

In danger right now: 911 in the US, 999 in the UK, or your local emergency number.

📄 IF YOU HAVE TO TEXT

If calling isn't safe, the US hotline takes texts: text **START** to **88788**. Or send one person you trust:

Can you call me? I'm not okay, and I need to talk.

🚫 DON'T SAY

~~"Maybe I'm overreacting."~~ If you're scared, you're not overreacting. It counts.

📞 IF THEY SAY NO / DON'T ANSWER

If the line is busy, try again, or use the text line. If you think they check your phone, call from a phone they can't check, like a friend's.

Don't use the breakup cards in this file on someone who scares you. The people on those lines can help you plan how to leave safely. And you call them. I mean it.

The usage log

Every time you use a card, write one line. That's the deal.

Date, which card, what happened, and how you felt, before and after, like “sick > fine.” Tick the box if you made the call, or said it face to face. Don't write an essay. A line is plenty. The first line is mine, so you can see how it goes.

DATE	CARD	WHAT HAPPENED	HOW I FELT <i>before > after</i>	CALLED
Tue	7	<i>Called, no answer. Sent one message, phone in the drawer.</i>	<i>sick > okay</i>	☒
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐

The usage log, continued

DATE	CARD	WHAT HAPPENED	HOW I FELT <i>before > after</i>	CALLED
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐

Read it back

Every month or so, read this log from the top.

- ① Count the ticks in the Called column: _____ calls. Every one is a time you were braver than you felt.
- ② Read just the “after” side of How I felt. See how many say better.
- ③ Go back to page 5, to the conversation you were putting off.
☐ I had it, on _____

That’s not luck, kid. That’s a record.

The five cards to read tonight

No crisis right now? Good. Read these five while you're calm, so the words are already in your pocket when you need them.

☐ **CARD 1 I want to ask them out, and I'm scared.** p. 8

THE DAY-AND-A-TIME RULE: *Sometime is never.*

Because the best thing that ever happened to me started with eleven cents and a question.

☐ **CARD 3 They said yes to a call. Now I have to dial.** p. 10

THE REASON RULE: *You don't need a speech, you need a reason.*

Because when they say yes, you'll want to know what comes after "Hi."

☐ **CARD 7 They haven't texted back in two days.** p. 14

THE ONE KNOCK RULE: *Call once. If there's no answer, send one message. Then the phone goes in a drawer.*

Because it happens to everybody, and the card is easier to read before your stomach starts doing the thing.

☐ **CARD 12 I need to ask "what are we?"** p. 19

THE SITUATION-SHIP RULE: *A boat with no captain just goes in circles.*

Because the longer you wait to ask, the harder it gets to ask.

☐ **CARD 18 I need to end this situationship.** p. 25

THE SHORT-IS-KIND RULE: *Short is kind. The long version is for you, not for them.*

Because knowing how to leave is what lets you stay only where you're wanted.

And know where card 25 (p. 32) is. I hope you never need it.

TONIGHT'S HOMEWORK

Pick one of the five. Say its script out loud, once, in the shower, in the car, wherever nobody's listening. Then go to bed. You're more ready than you were this morning.

Lou's Rules

All of them, on one page. Print it, cut along the dotted line, and stick it on the fridge, where you'll see it at eleven o'clock at night.

- 1 The Eleven O'Clock Rule** CARD 8
If somebody only texts you after eleven, you're not a plan. Hey is not a question.
- 2 The Tuesday Rule** CARD 4
First date on a Tuesday. A coffee and a walk, one hour.
- 3 The Face-Down Rule** CARD 14
On a date, the phone goes face down.
- 4 The Day-and-a-Time Rule** CARD 1
Sometime is never.
- 5 The Bakery Rule** CARD 2
You can only buy so much bread before you have to say something.
- 6 The Reason Rule** CARD 3
You don't need a speech, you need a reason.
- 7 The Say-the-Word Rule** CARD 5
If it's a date, call it a date.
- 8 The Easy-No Rule** CARD 6
Ask once, out loud, and make it easy to say no.
- 9 The One Knock Rule** CARD 7
Call once. If there's no answer, send one message. Then the phone goes in a drawer.
- 10 The Dimmer Switch Rule** CARD 9
When somebody turns the lights down slow, you're allowed to ask if the party's over.
- 11 The Front Door Rule** CARD 10
If you left by the back door, you come back by the front, with an explanation.
- 12 The Monday Sauce Rule** CARD 11
Sauce is better the next day. So is "I had a really good time."
- 13 The Situation-ship Rule** CARD 12
A boat with no captain just goes in circles.
- 14 The Somebody-Has-To Rule** CARD 13
Somebody has to say it first. Might as well be the brave one.
- 15 The Schedule Rule** CARD 15
Once is bad luck. Every week is a schedule.
- 16 The Thank-You-First Rule** CARD 16
Somebody was brave enough to ask. Thank them before you say no.
- 17 The Pull-the-Cord Rule** CARD 17
You don't owe anybody a speech. You owe them one sentence.
- 18 The Short-Is-Kind Rule** CARD 18
Short is kind. The long version is for you, not for them.
- 19 The No-Trial Rule** CARD 19
A breakup is a decision, not a trial. You don't need to win the case.
- 20 The I-Was-Wrong Rule** CARD 20
"I was wrong. I'm sorry." Then stop talking.
- 21 The Noon Rule** CARD 21
What you sent at midnight, you fix by noon.
- 22 The Bus Driver's Rule** CARD 22
Late is late. Don't explain the traffic. Apologize for the wait.
- 23 The Ouch Rule** CARD 23
If it stung, say "ouch" out loud. What they do next is your answer.
- 24 The One-Word Rule** CARD 24
No is one word. It doesn't need an explanation, and it doesn't get a recount.
- 25 The Bravest Call Rule** CARD 25
The bravest call in this whole file isn't to them.
- 26 The Gift Rule** P. 6
A no is an answer. An answer is a gift.
- 27 Angie's Goodnight Rule** P. 38
You can go to bed mad. You can't go to bed without saying goodnight.

The first-call cheat card

Fill it in before you dial. I kept a pencil by my phone for sixty years. You can use the notes on your phone. I won't tell.

Calling _____ at _____ *The time I said. Not around then. Then.*

My reason _____

You don't need a speech, you need a reason.

THE FIRST THIRTY SECONDS

"Hi, it's _____. Is now a good time? I was thinking about _____ and I wanted to hear your voice."

If it's a bad time: "No problem, when's better?" New time: _____

TWO THINGS THEY TOLD ME THAT I WANT TO ASK ABOUT

1 _____

2 _____

IF MY MIND GOES BLANK, I CAN SAY

- "Sorry, I'm a little nervous. I'm glad I called, though."
- "Okay, tell me the best thing that happened to you this week."
- "What are you looking forward to this weekend?"

THE PLAN I'LL ASK FOR

Day _____ Time _____ Place _____

MY GOODBYE

"I should let you go. I'm really glad I called."

After you hang up: one line in the log on page 33. Then go get a glass of water. You earned it.

Angie's Goodnight Rule

You can go to bed mad. You can't go to bed without saying goodnight.

Sixty-five years, Angie and me said goodnight every night. Every night. Even when we were fighting. Even the night she shut herself in the bathroom, too mad to come out. I said it through the bathroom door, and she said it back: "Goodnight, Louie." I was wrong that night, by the way. I was wrong a lot.

Here's why it works. A fight is about one thing. Goodnight is about everything else: I'm still here, we're still us, we'll pick this up tomorrow. You don't have to fix the fight before bed. Some fights need a night's sleep. You just don't let the fight have the last word.

SAY THIS

AT BEDTIME: "I'm still upset, and I still love you. Goodnight. Let's talk at breakfast."

THROUGH THE DOOR: "Goodnight. I'm not going anywhere."

IF YOU LIVE APART: a thirty-second call. "I'm still mad, and I'm not going anywhere. Goodnight." Then hang up and sleep.

WHAT IT ISN'T

It isn't a rule to force a talk. If they've asked for space, the goodnight is "Okay. I'll give you space. Goodnight." And then you give it.

And it isn't for a home where you're scared. If saying goodnight feels dangerous, this isn't a fight. It's [card 25 \(p. 32\)](#).

Ten cheap Tuesday dates

One soda, two straws. The date was never about the soda.

Nobody's trying to impress anybody on a Tuesday, and cheap is good: when there's nothing fancy to look at, you look at each other. Tick them off as you go.

-
- ☐ **1 One soda, two straws.** Find a counter that still makes a milkshake or a float, and split one. Leave a tip. I left a penny. Times have changed.
 - ☐ **2 The end of the line.** Ride a city bus to the last stop and back. Sit up front and make up stories about the people getting on. This one's personal.
 - ☐ **3 The free museum night.** Lots of museums have a free evening or a pay-what-you-can day. Pick one room and stay there.
 - ☐ **4 The one-pot dinner.** Cook one thing together. Somebody chops, somebody stirs, and the phones go face down.
 - ☐ **5 The stoop.** Two coffees, a front step or a bench, and an hour of watching the street go by.
 - ☐ **6 The library swap.** Walk the shelves and pick a book for each other. It's free, and you learn a lot from what somebody picks for you.
 - ☐ **7 The walk with a destination.** Pick a bridge, a view or a park across town. Walk there, and split a slice at the end.
 - ☐ **8 Teach me something.** A card game, a song, a recipe your grandmother made. Whoever loses makes the coffee next time.
 - ☐ **9 The free show.** An open mic, a concert in the park, a high school play. Bad singing is a great thing to laugh about together.
 - ☐ **10 Breakfast instead of dinner.** Cheaper, earlier, and nobody's tired yet. A diner counter is the most honest room in America.
-

The small print

Short, honest, and in plain English.

Lou is a character

Grandpa Lou is an AI-created fictional character. His face, his voice and his stories were made with AI, and Angie, Nicky and the bus route belong to his story, not to a real family. The good sense is real. The grandpa isn't.

What this isn't

This file is general advice for adults. It isn't therapy or counseling, and it isn't medical or legal advice. No script makes anybody want you, and nothing in here is meant to pressure, trick or talk anyone into anything. Use it for honesty, never for games.

When it's more than a dating problem

These are free, and calling one is the strong move.

- **Scared of someone you're with.** US: National Domestic Violence Hotline, 1-800-799-7233 (or text START to 88788). UK: Refuge, National Domestic Abuse Helpline, 0808 2000 247.
- **In a dark place.** US: call or text 988. UK and Ireland: Samaritans, 116 123.
- **In danger right now.** 911 in the US, 999 in the UK, or your local emergency number.

For everybody

Every card works for anybody: any gender, and anybody you love. When a card says "they," it means whoever you're calling.

Yours to keep

This file is for your own use. Please don't share or resell it. If a friend needs it, tell them where you got it.

Now put this down and pick up the phone.

Don't text. Call.

Lou